Bill's Helix Cheat Sheet / Command Reference

1 Introduction

1.1 Metadata

- Document version: 1.1.0-beta, 27-Apr-2026
- Based on Helix version: 25.07.1
- Built with Typst version: 0.14.2
- Distributed at:
  https://github.com/wrwetzel/Helix-Cheat-Sheet
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1.2 Definitions

- **file** - data on storage device, e.g., hard disk or ssd
- **buffers** - data from one or more files loaded into memory
- **view** - one or more visual areas on screen showing one or more buffers
- **workspace** - the directory from which Helix was launched
- **under selection** - the entire word containing the cursor
- **alternate buffer** - the previous active buffer
- **textual line** - text as defined by the newline character
- **visual line** - what appears on screen after word-wrapping
- **range** - a selection; one in single-selection, multiple in multi-selection

1.3 Typographic Conventions

- `word` - alphanumeric, punctuation-delimited
- `WORD` - whitespace-delimited
- `Ctrl-c` - Ctrl and c key pressed simultaneous.
- `Alt-c` - Alt and c key pressed simultaneous.
- Some Alt and Ctrl characters may conflict with terminal capture and require terminal configuration change.
- `␣c` is space followed by the character c.
- Metavars `<regex>`, `<file>` and `<ch>` represent user input. The angle-brackets are not part of the input.
- `␣`, `<minus>`, and `<under>` used for clarity. `<enter>`, `<del>`, `<bksp>`, etc. used for non-printing control characters.
- Commands are separated from definitions by a dash. Synonyms are separated by commas. Related commands are separated by slashes. The separators are never part of the command though commands may include a dash, comma, or slash.

1.4 Launching

```
helix
helix <file>
helix <file1> <file2> ... <file n>
helix <directory>
helix --help
hx in some distributions or by alias
```

2 Primary Commands

2.1 Editing Paradigm

Selection first, action second. *mode* and *count* are optional.

```
[mode][count][select][command]
          v3wd - enter select mode, select 3 words, delete
```

2.2 Regular Expressions

Helix uses Rust's regex. Escape following metachars with <backslash> when searching for literal value.

```
  . - any character
  * - zero or more
  + - one or more
  ? - zero or one / lazy match
  ^ - start of line / negation in class
  $ - end of line
  ( ) - capture group
  [ ] - character class
  { } - repetition count
  | - alternation
  \ - escape character itself
```

2.3 Essentials

2.3.1 Undo / Repeat / Normal Mode

```
       u / U - undo / redo change in linear history
Alt-u / Alt-U - move backward / forward in tree history
  :ear / :lat - move backward / forward in history by step count or time span (1s, 2m, 3h, 4d)
    <nn><cmd> - repeat <cmd> <nn> times
          Esc - return to normal mode
```

2.3.2 Quit

Add ! suffix to force operation.

```
     :wq - write current buffer and quit
:wq <file> - write current buffer to <file> and quit
     :wqa - write all buffer(s) and quit
      :q - quit current buffer, exits if last
```

2.3.3 Files

```
  :o <file> - open <file> in new buffer
  :w <file> - write current buffer to <file>
 :hs <file> - open/create <file> in new horizontal split
 :vs <file> - open/create <file> in new vertical split
      ␣wf - open/create file(s) under selection(s) in horizontal split
      ␣wF - open/create file(s) under selection(s) in vertical split
       gf - open/create file(s) under selection, open url under selection.
      ␣f - open file picker at LSP workspace root
      ␣F - open file picker at current working directory
      ␣g - open changed file picker
```

2.3.3.1 File Picker

All pickers, here and elsewhere, are *fuzzy* - they tolerate gaps in the input, ranking closer matches higher.

```
  <enter> - open selected in current view
   Ctrl-s - open selected in new horizontal split
   Ctrl-v - open selected in new vertical split
```

2.3.4 Buffers

Add ! suffix to force operation. Buffers named by file they contain.

```
     :n - create new scratch buffer
    :bc - close current buffer
   :bca - close all buffers
   :bco - close all but current buffer
    :bn - next buffer
     ␣b - open buffer picker
     ga - go to last accessed/alternate buffer
     gm - go to last modified/alternate buffer
     gn - go to next buffer
     gp - go to previous buffer
```

2.3.5 Views

Ctrl-w and `␣w` are synonymous.

```
  ␣ws / ␣wv - split horizontal / vertical, current buffer
 ␣wns / ␣wnv - split horizontal / vertical, new buffer
      ␣wq - close current split
      ␣wo - close all but current split
      ␣ww - next split
  ␣wh/j/k/l - move to buffer left / up / down / right
  ␣wH/J/K/L - swap split with buffer on left / up / down / right
      ␣wt - transpose split
```

2.3.5.1 View Movement

Commands shown with `z` prefix. The prefix is not used in sticky mode, which is a view-only navigation mode appropriate for browsing a file without editing.

```
       Z - enter sticky mode, exit with Esc
  zz, zc - align to center
      zt - align to top
      zb - align to bottom
      zm - align to middle horizontally
      zj - scroll down
      zk - scroll up
```

2.3.6 Help

```
  :tutor - open tutorial
      ␣? - open command palette
```

2.4 Movement

2.4.1 Cursor Movement

Normal Mode: motion replaces selection
Select Mode: motion extends selection

```
    h/j/k/l - left / up / down / right
     gh, g| - beginning of line
     <nn>g| - column <nn>
         gl - end of line
         gg - top of file
<nn>G, g<nn>g - line <nn>
         ge - bottom of file
         gw - two-char labels on words, label to go to word
         g. - to last modification in current file
         gj - down textual line
         gk - up textual line
         gs - first non-white-space char
         gt - top of screen
         gc - middle of screen
         gb - bottom of screen
```

2.4.2 By Language Server Protocol

Requires LSP support.

```
     gd - go to definition
     gy - go to type definition
     gr - go to references
     gi - go to implementation
     ]d - next diagnostic
     [d - prior diagnostic
     ]D - last diagnostic
     [D - first diagnostic
```

2.4.3 By Treesitter - Syntax

Requires Treesitter support.

```
  ]f, [f - to next, prior function
  ]t, [t - to next, prior type definition
  ]T, [T - to next, prior test
  ]a, [a - to next, prior arg
  ]c, [c - to next, prior comment
  ]g, [g - to next, prior change
  ]G, [G - to last, first change
    Alt-e - move to end of parent node in syntax tree
    Alt-b - move to start of parent node in syntax tree
```

2.4.4 By Page

```
  Ctrl-b - page up
  Ctrl-f - page down
  Ctrl-u - half page up
  Ctrl-d - half page down
```

2.5 Selection

Selection: a range of characters between anchor and cursor
Normal Mode: move and select
Select Mode: move and extend selection

2.5.1 Operations

```
      % - select whole file
   Alt-; - swap anchor and cursor
   Alt-: - selection to normal direction (cursor at end)
   Alt-o - expand selection syntax-aware
   Alt-i - shrink selection
       ; - collapse selection(s) to cursor(s)
```

2.5.2 By TextObjects

```
ma<ch> / mi<ch> - match around / inside the object indicated by <ch> below:
      w / W - word / WORD
          p - paragraph
  (, [, ', etc.- specified surround pairs
          m - closest surround pair
          f - function
          t - type or class
          a - argument/parameter
          c - comment
          T - test
          g - change git hunk
```

2.5.3 By Syntactic Objects

```
  w / W - to start of next word / WORD
  e / E - to end of current word / WORD
  b / B - to start of current word / WORD
      x - current line, extend by line
      X - extend to line
 Alt-x - shrink to line bounds
     ]p - to next paragraph
     [p - to prior paragraph
```

2.5.4 By Treesitter - Syntax

Requires Treesitter support.

```
 Alt-o - expand selection to parent syntax node
 Alt-i - shrink syntax tree object selection
 Alt-p - select previous sibling node in syntax tree
 Alt-n - select next sibling node in syntax tree
 Alt-a - select all sibling nodes in syntax tree
 Alt-I - select all children nodes in syntax tree
```

2.5.5 By Character Value

Lower case: forward
Upper case: backward

```
f<ch>, F<ch> - to <ch> inclusive (find)
t<ch>, T<ch> - to <ch> exclusive (till)
    Alt-.  - repeat last find / till
```

2.6 Select Mode

Movement: extends selection
Search: adds to selection

```
     v - toggle select mode
   Esc - return to normal
     ) - cycle primary selection forward
     ( - cycle primary selection backward
  Alt-,  - remove primary selection
```

2.7 Multiple Selections

Multiple independent cursors / selections, one is *primary*.

2.7.1 Creating

Create multiple selections from selection.

```
s<regex> - matches become selections
       S - split on match
   Alt-s - split on newlines
 C / Alt-C - add selection below / above
```

2.7.2 Operations

```
       & - align on primary cursor
Alt-<minus> - merge selections
Alt-<under> - merge consecutive selections
       ,  - remove all except primary selection
  Alt-,   - remove primary selection
   ( / )  - rotate primary backwards / forwards
Alt-( / Alt-) - rotate content backward / forward
       K  - keep selections matching the regex
  Alt-K   - remove selections matching the regex
```

2.8 Alter Buffer Content

2.8.1 Insert

```
     i - before selection
     a - after selection
     I - at start of line
     A - at end of line
     o - add line and insert below cursor
     O - add line and insert above cursor
   Esc - end insert (return to normal)
     . - repeat last insert
```

2.8.2 Add

```
    ]␣ - newline below
    [␣ - newline above
 ms<ch> - add delim <ch> around selection
```

2.8.3 Delete

```
     d - selection -> yank buf, delete selection
  Alt-d - delete, no save
md<ch> - delete delim <ch> around selection
```

2.8.4 Change

```
     c - selection -> yank buf, change selection
  Alt-c - change, no save
     = - format by LSP
mr<ch1><ch2> - replace delim <ch1> with <ch2>
```

2.8.5 Indent Lines

```
     > - Indent line(s) containing selection
     < - Undent line(s) containing selection
```

2.8.6 Change Case

Change case of all letters in selection

```
     ~ - change case
     ` - set lowercase
  Alt-` - set uppercase
```

2.8.7 Comments

All apply to selection.

```
  ␣c, Ctrl-c - Toggle comment
        ␣C - Toggle block comment
   ␣Alt-C - Toggle line comment
```

2.8.8 Increment / Decrement

```
  Ctrl-a - increment the selected number
  Ctrl-x - decrement the selected number
```

2.8.9 Miscellaneous

```
       J - join lines in a selection
  Alt-J - join lines inside selection and select the inserted space
<under> - trim whitespace from selection
:reflow <width> - wrap selection to <width>, default 80
   :sort - sort ranges in selection
:format - format file using external formatter / language server
```

2.9 Copy / Paste / Replace

```
       y - selection -> yank buf
       p - paste yank buf after the cursor
       P - paste yank buf before the cursor
      ␣y - yank selection(s) -> system clipboard
      ␣Y - yank main selection -> system clipboard
  ␣p / ␣P - paste clipboard after / before selections(s)
      ␣R - replace selection(s) with clipboard
    r<ch> - replace selection with <ch>
       R - replace selection with yank buf
       " - select register to yank to or paste from
```

2.10 Search

```
  /<regex> - search forward for regex
  ?<regex> - search backward for regex
     n, N - next, previous match
        * - search for current selection, respect word boundaries
   Alt-* - search for current selection
```

2.11 Registers

Identified by single char <ch>

```
  "<ch> - change to reg <ch>
  "<ch>y - yank into reg <ch>
  "<ch>p - paste from reg <ch>
  "<ch>R - replace with reg <ch>
```

2.12 Macros

```
  "<ch>Q - toggle capture to reg <ch>, default @
  "<ch>q - play macro in reg <ch>, default @
```

2.13 Jumplists

```
  Ctrl-s - save current position to jumplist
  Ctrl-i - move forward in jumplist
  Ctrl-o - move backwards in jumplist
      ␣j - open jumplist picker
```

2.14 Match Mode

With regard to balanced delimiters.

```
      mm - go to matching delim
   mi<ch> - match inside delim <ch>
   ma<ch> - match around delim <ch>
   ms<ch> - add delim <ch> around selection
   md<ch> - delete delim <ch> around selection
mr<ch1><ch2> - replace delim <ch1> with <ch2>
```

2.15 Shell

All commands pipe each selection to shell command.

```
      | - replace selection(s) with output
  Alt-| - ignore output
      ! - insert output before each selection(s)
  Alt-! - append output after each selection(s)
      $ - keep selection(s) where command returned 0
```

2.16 Approaching an IDE

```
  ␣G - debug - experimental
  ␣k - show documentation for item under cursor
  ␣s - open document symbol picker
  ␣S - open workspace symbol picker
  ␣d - open document diagnostics picker
  ␣D - open workspace diagnostics picker
  ␣r - rename symbol
  ␣a - apply code action
  ␣h - select symbol references for symbol under cursor
```

2.17 Editor Configuration

```
     :config-open - open the config file
:config-open-workspace - open the workspace config file
   :config-reload - reload the config file
```

2.18 Miscellaneous

```
  ␣` - open last picker
  ␣/ - open global search in workspace folder picker
```

3 Commands in Specific Contexts

3.1 Insert Mode Editing

Navigation keys shown.

```
                    Ctrl-s - commit undo checkpoint
                    Ctrl-x - autocomplete
                    Ctrl-r - insert a register content
          Ctrl-w, Alt-<bksp> - delete previous word
            Alt-d, Alt-<del> - delete next word
                    Ctrl-u - delete to start of line
                    Ctrl-k - delete to end of line
   Ctrl-h, <bksp>, Shift-<bksp> - delete previous char
                 Ctrl-d, <del> - delete next char
                Ctrl-j, <enter> - insert new line

     <Up>, <Down>, <Left>, <Right>,- usual meaning but discouraged
<PageUp>, <PageDown>, <Home>, <End>
```

3.2 Command Line Editing

```
      Esc, Ctrl-c - close prompt
          <enter> - open selected
            <tab> - select next completion item
        <backtab> - select previous completion item
           Alt-b - backward a word
          Ctrl-b - backward a char
           Alt-f - forward a word
          Ctrl-f - forward a char
          Ctrl-e - to prompt end
          Ctrl-a - to prompt start
Ctrl-w, Ctrl-<bksp> - delete previous word
  Alt-d, Ctrl-<del> - delete next word
          Ctrl-u - delete to start of line
          Ctrl-k - delete to end of line
     <bksp>, Ctrl-h - delete previous char
      <del>, Ctrl-d - delete next char
          Ctrl-s - insert a word under doc cursor (may be changed to Ctrl-r Ctrl-w later)
          Ctrl-p - select previous history
          Ctrl-n - select next history
          Ctrl-r - insert the content of the register selected by following input char
```

3.3 Pickers

Navigation keys shown.

```
Shift-<tab>, Ctrl-p, <Up> - previous entry
    <tab>, Ctrl-n, <Down> - next entry
                   <Home> - to first entry
                    <End> - to last entry
          Ctrl-u, <PageUp> - page up
        Ctrl-d, <PageDown> - page down
                  <enter> - open selected
             Alt-<enter> - open selected in the background without closing the picker
                  Ctrl-s - open horizontally
                  Ctrl-v - open vertically
                  Ctrl-t - toggle preview
             Esc, Ctrl-c - close picker
```

3.4 Popups

Displays documentation for item under cursor.

```
  Ctrl-u - scroll up
  Ctrl-d - scroll down
```

3.5 Completion Menu

Displays documentation for the selected completion item. Any other keypresses result in the completion being accepted.

```
Shift-Tab, Ctrl-p - previous entry
      Tab, Ctrl-n - next entry
          <enter> - close menu and accept completion
           Ctrl-c - close menu and reject completion
```

3.6 Signature-help Popup

Displays the signature of the selected completion item.

```
  Alt-p - previous signature
  Alt-n - next signature
```